

know this guy, and if he says it's true, it is almost undoubtedly true." I only found out about this a few years later when, by pure chance, we were both on the same plane, and he told me what had happened. When I arrived for my talk, I was expecting maybe 40 or 50 people to show up for a fairly sedate presentation. Instead, the room was overflowing with about 300 people.

**I guess it shows that mathematicians are more interested in blackjack than people think.**

Actually, a good part of the audience didn't look like mathematicians. They had sunglasses on and pinky rings. So I gave my talk. At the end of the talk, I had about 50 copies of my paper to hand out. As soon as I was finished, the audience just surged for the papers. I dropped them on the podium and took off out the back. There were a lot of reporters who were very interested in my talk. One of the reporters was Tom Wolfe.

***The Tom Wolfe?***

Yes, white suit and all. He interviewed me and was very excited about it. He wrote a story for the AP wire, which set off a furor. Twenty thousand letters rained into the MIT math department. I had all six secretaries answering letters. I didn't estimate how long it would take to answer all the letters, just like, at first, I didn't estimate how long it would take to do the calculations for my original blackjack betting system using a desk calculator. After the secretaries had soldiered through answering several thousand letters, I was finally told, much to my relief, "You're tying up the entire math department. We can't do this anymore."

I also had people calling who wanted to bankroll me. One particularly persistent caller was a fellow from New York named Emanuel Kimmel who claimed he knew his way around the gambling world. He wanted to bankroll me with \$100,000. I decided to meet with him. One evening in February, on a typical terrible Boston weather night, a midnight blue Cadillac pulled up, and two attractive, young, blonde women wearing fur coats got out. They were followed by Kimmel who appeared to be about 65 years old, on the short side, with a shock of white hair, and wearing a large cashmere coat. He came into the house and introduced the young ladies as his nieces. My wife, Vivian, looked at them suspiciously.